see that it will be gradually covered by plant community again and become fertile. Such successive replacement of one type of plant community by the other of the same area/ place is known as plant **succession**. The first invaded plants in a barren area are called **pioneers**. On the other hand, a series of transitional developments of plant communities one after another in a given area are called **seral communities**. At the end a final stage and a final plant community gets established which are called as climax and climax community respectively.

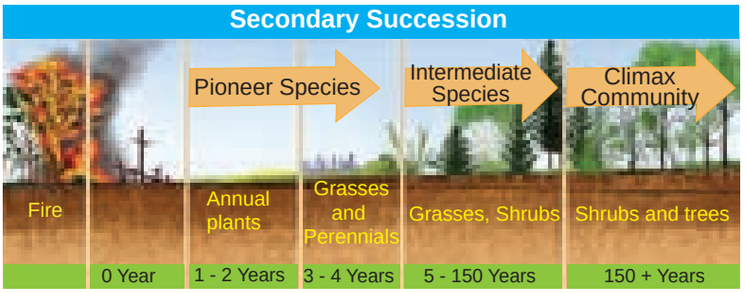


Figure 7.18: Diagrammatic representation of secondary succession

7.3.1 Characteristics of ecological succession

- It is a systematic process which causes changes in specific structure of plant community.
- It is resultant of changes of abiotic and biotic factors.
- It transforms unstable community into a stable community.
- Gradual progression in species diversity, total biomass, niche specialisation, and humus content of soil takes place.
- It progresses from simple food chain to complex food web.
- It modifies the lower and simple life form to the higher life forms.
- It creates inter-dependence of plants and animals.

7.3.2 Types of succession

The various types of succession have been classified in different ways on the basis of different aspects. These are as follows:

1. Primary succession - The development of plant community in a barren area where no community existed before is called primary succession. The plants which colonize first in a barren area is called **pioneer species** or **primary community** or **primary colonies**. Generally, Primary succession takes a very long time for the occurrence in any region.

Example: Microbes, Lichen, Mosses.

2. Secondary succession - The development of a plant community in an area where an already developed community has been destroyed by some natural disturbance (Fire, flood, human activity) is known as **secondary succession**. Generally, This succession takes less time than the time taken for primary succession.

	Primary succession	Secondary succession
1	Developing in an barren area	Developing in disturbed area
2	Initiated due to a biological or any other external factors	Starts due to external factors only
3	No soil, while primary succession starts	It starts where soil covers is already present
4	Pioneer species come from outside environment	Pioneer species develop from existing environment
5	It takes more time to complete	It takes comparatively less time to complete

Table 1: Differences between primary and secondary succession

Example: The forest destroyed by fire and excessive lumbering may be re-occupied by herbs over a period of times.

3. Allogenic succession

Allogeneic succession occurs as a result of

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